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Jim Cullum

Cornetist Jim Cullum is one of the most recognized artists in traditional jazz. He has directed the Jim Cullum Jazz Band since 1973 and appears with this group on the high profile radio show "Riverwalk, Live from the Landing." They have recorded 45 albums and Jim has played an important role in keeping American music of the early twentieth century alive.

Jim was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan filming at the IAJE. I'm really pleased to have Jim Cullum with me today, trumpet player and band leader, and I think really has significantly made a big measure with your marketing too, your marketing team. You guys are out there.

JC: We try.

MR: I really, I'm impressed by how much exposure you're getting on the internet and all that and with the radio show and everything. So you're doing good stuff.

JC: Thanks.

MR: I was fortunate enough to be able to hear your presentation this morning talking about traditional jazz, and they called it alive and well. Do you think it's alive and well?

JC: I think there are opportunities, just like there are in any area, to do things with it and present it and carry it forward. I don't think it's dead on the table like some people feel like it is. Because there are problems in presenting it that it's not the game is over. I just don't think that you have to accept it and we have to reinvent the whole business all the time.

MR: Problems in presenting it would you say?

JC: Well I mean it has been buoyed up for a long time by people that are of the World War II generation who are now dying off. And people that heard — this whole generation that heard jazz at Eddie Condon's and Nick's in the Village and were also fans of the big bands and that were devotees of Artie Shaw or the Bob Crosby band or whatever. Those people are now all in their eighties if they're still around. And so there's not much opportunity – the music can't be carried forward very much further on the strength of those people's good will and taste.

MR: There was some talk this morning about labels and you really do have to label things sometimes. Like Mat Domber's record label, he calls it classic jazz and we call some things traditional. And sometimes the word "trad" — I wonder if that word doesn't have some connotations.

JC: For some people it does. I've had this experience where they say, the people in the crowd, I'll get off the stage and somebody'll grab me and say, "When are you going to stop playing that — something besides Dixieland." And the next person I'll come to or two or three people over will say, "Well will you please play some Dixieland?" So it depends on your definitions. And what Domber was saying this morning was that the music has collective improvisation that starts sounding like New Orleans, has this what we call Dixieland effect in it. But what is that? Well if you took the Basie band rhythm section and you took three horns and put 'em up there in front of the band and had them improvising, you know, that's basically what you'd have. That's basically what our band is. You'd have a four piece swinging rhythm section, four beat guitar, four beat bass, the drums and the piano grooving right with that, and that's the key to a band like this. And then you put three improvising horns in front of it you're going to have pretty much a classic New Orleans sounding band. That's kind of what we love to do the most and that's what we do with our band and there are offshoots of this. So if you want to stereotype that and — the listener is the one that puts it in the category you know. And we do things sometimes that are so, they're so oriented and built around the riff — you know the riff, maybe the people getting this video don't exactly know even what I mean by a riff, but when you repeat the same pattern over and over and over. Like [scats] that's what we call a riff. And so the harmonics may change a little behind the riff, same pattern over and over. And we do that a lot, and quit sounding quite so much like this New Orleans stereotype. The Basie band, the early Basie band was built on a lot of riffs. Because once you get beyond having just three horns, and you get four horns and five horns, well then you have to stay in pattern so everybody can grab a note and —

MR: Yeah. You've got to arrange it a little bit more.

JC: Arrange it a little more. And sometimes they didn't have any music, you just go with what you can sort of listen for another harmony note. We had Sweets Edison on the show one time and he told a story about playing with Basie and he says he went into Basie and he says, "I'm frustrated" he says, "I'm going to have to give my notice." And so Basie says, "Why, you sound real good," he says, "what's the problem?" He says, "I can't find a note, I can't find a note." There was all the other guys that had all the notes from the rhythm, and he can't find a harmony note to harmonize a note to the riff.

MR: Right.

JC: You've got this big band going on there. And he says so Basie says, "Well you sound real good, I love the way you play," he says, "let me just say if you find a note tonight play the same damn note every night."

MR: That's a good one.

JC: He's trying to find a note. You find that note keep playing it. Well anyway —

MR: But the guys next to him wouldn't want, they don't want him to have their note.

JC: No. Get off my note. Get off my note.

MR: There's only so many notes. Try the second alto player's note.

JC: That's right. So anyway, the life of the riff things. So sometimes you're playing riffs in harmony like that. With three horns it's pretty easy to riff and find a note. It's easy. It's pretty easy to get a note.

MR: Do you guys rehearse that kind of thing?

JC: Usually not.

MR: Yeah.

JC: Usually we don't. Sometimes we're standing up there playing and I'll say to the clarinet player I'm going to play this pattern [scats] and I'll say I'll start on the G or whatever it is, so then he'll know. And then maybe he says to the trombone player, "Start on the B flat" or something. So everybody just listens and then fall — you'd be amazed at how fast they fall into it. And of course we do it all the time. And it's what makes the music fun and fresh and spontaneous and full of life, and all of that stuff.

MR: Well let me put a — let me see if I can find this little piece right here.

[audio interlude]

MR: It sounds great first of all.

JC: Well you see it's a combination. First a riff, then it goes into the collective ensemble thing. And that's one of the things we've tried to make part of our style. A lot of the tunes are kind of built that way.

MR: Right.

JC: So you go back and forth between the little sort of arranged passage to a completely open loose passage and then back again.

MR: And when you get to the bridge, it's like —

JC: When you get to the bridge and usually it becomes a solo or it becomes —

MR: Spontaneous.

JC: Spontaneous, whatever it is.

MR: Is it hard to find musicians who are capable of that for you? You've had good luck.

JC: That's critical. I mean if we're going to do it we've got to have people that can do it. So I have been able to find them and get guys to do it. One of the keys is that we're there doing it six nights a week, over and over and over. So we're constantly playing together. And we sort of think together, feel, it's easier. You can take somebody that's a stranger, you're very sympathetic with them and you just fall into things easily with a stranger, but usually the way these things work best and it's the advantage of an organized band.

MR: Well I sure hope to get down there someday but I was wondering, do you have a dancing crowd?

JC: It's a very small place. It's little tables and they're all jammed in and people are real crowded and there's not a dance floor.

MR: Okay. Would you prefer there was one? Do you play ever for people to dance or not?

JC: We do play dances once in a while and the music is great dance music, as you know. It's the ultimate dance music. It's fun to dance to it. Sometimes people have an idea that because it's — so many decades have passed since it was dance music that they're not supposed to be dancing to it. But it's great dance music and we do play for dancing. That was originally what the music was, it was music for people to dance to.

MR: Can I assume that you think of jazz as an art form?

JC: Yes.

MR: Okay. Is the music that John Coltrane did more of an art form than the music of Bix Beiderbecke?

JC: I think it's different music but not more of an art form. I don't think music gets more artistic than Bix Beiderbecke. I don't think any art gets — I think it's the consummate art. It think Beiderbecke is the — I mean he is the great American artist. I mean you put him up on the wall. I don't think it gets, I don't think art gets any finer.

MR: I'm not sure that I picked the right person, but I sort of get the impression, what we were talking about this morning about where traditional jazz fits in the music scene today and in the IAJE. And somehow I personally get the impression that people don't think of the music from the 1920s and 30s as artistic as they do jazz from the bop period on. Is it that it became, like because the music was too much of an entertainment type thing?

JC: I can't answer that. I don't know. I can conjecture about it but I don't know if I have a definitive answer or why they feel the way they feel about it. I do know that we've gone through a metamorphosis there and that modern jazz just represents a whole different part of American life and culture and it's a different scene, different artists, a different thing you know. So I'm more comfortable talking about earlier jazz forms. I'm more expert about them.

MR: It's interesting to speculate if you would have been doing this without your father's influence? Do you think that that was — how significant was that for you?

JC: It was very important. It was very important. I'm not sure what would have — how I would have come along if I hadn't been born into my family, my existing family. And my father was a musician and my earliest memories are of the downstairs jam session. We lived in a two story house and I was awake, and I guess I must have been four years old or something. And toddled downstairs and they would be going at it. And it would be the middle of the night and you know, and the musicians would all be playing there and there would be a lot of smoking and booze and all of that. And there would always be a little clutch of wives and women girlfriends and all hanging around, and the guys would be

playing. And then if they weren't the records would be playing. But the music was just almost constantly going. So I heard a lot of music and there wasn't any television, no kid was sitting in front of a television because there wasn't any television yet as I was growing up. I think personally it was a blessing to be born before television. It was a great advantage. I was born before — I woke up in front of the Victrola you know. And the instruments, and they were playing. And I heard a lot of music. So if I had grown up out on a farm or something where people weren't playing music I don't know, I would have been a different person.

MR: Right. Did your father make a living playing music?

JC: He did from time to time. He went in and out of the business. At the time when I was growing up starting in 1945, that's the last year of the war, joined Jack Teagarden's band, and Jack Teagarden's big band, and then left town, came back, he was coming and going with traveling bands, with another band and he came back and so we lived in Dallas at that time. But before that my first few years, which I don't have memory of, he was working in my family's business and playing on the side and then he became a professional. And he did that. Then he stopped doing that after several years and went to Venezuela and lived in Venezuela, then he came back and he was a professional musician again for a while, then went to San Antonio and took up still another business. He had many talents. He was a real good businessman, a good executive, good salesman, he was an accountant and he was a very creative guy, he was a creative musician.

MR: Was he happy that you chose music as your career path?

JC: He was kind of surprised about the whole thing. I did it without his — I mean he didn't steer me to it. I did it sort of on my own. I was — when we went to San Antonio he put a collection of his — his 78 collection, which had gone to Venezuela and come back and many of the records had gotten broken in the process, but they were in a wooden chest and were temporarily in a small rent house, they were stuck in my little cubbyhole bedroom, that was the only place they would really fit. And we didn't even have a record player in the house at that point. My sister had one she brought home from college, a little portable one, and I got the record player and started playing the Louis Armstrong records. Louis Armstrong is, for people who never listen to jazz, it's automatic. It takes you in. At least that was my experience. I've seen other people, it's very easy to listen to. It has a certain passion, that's an integral part of it. It just takes you in and carries you along. And so that was my real introduction other than all the music I heard as a child, which was in the background. But I listened to those Armstrong records enough to begin to memorize them. You know I could whistle the whole record and that sort of thing. And then as my taste developed even more I discovered the Bix Beiderbecke records and I became even more fascinated and I would listen to these records all the time and

everyday after school I'd come home and listen to the Bix Beiderbecke records, and I memorized a whole bunch of those. So that was the way I got into the music as a performing musician, it was very unorthodox. Because I was able to have all this music in my mind, I could sing these Armstrong and Beiderbecke solos and before I ever had any instrument or any instruction or anything, I already had this music in my head. So then I decided that it would be pretty easy for me to do this, just all I had to was get an instrument. I decided I would get a trombone because I figured a trombone would be easy. I watched guys play the trombone and for a lower note you just push the slide out a little further. I thought well the trombone, it seemed like it would be easy to me. But in the meantime — and we were living in San Antonio at this point — and I was working as helping guys deliver things on a truck, and the truck was in downtown San Antonio making delivery and across the street from the place where we were making a delivery was a pawn shop. And in the pawn shop window was a cornet. And I looked at that thing and it was an old cornet, kind of beat up. There was some charm to it. Kind of looking like an old Victorian house or something, this old funny looking thing. And it didn't look sleek and modern or anything, like it would maybe would appeal to some people, but this thing had appeal to me. And I went over and the guy wanted twelve dollars for it. It was not in very good shape. And I negotiated. I was supposed to be over there watching the truck while the truck driver was making the delivery. I wasn't taking care of my business. And so I was negotiating with the thing. And so I bought the cornet for twelve dollars, I mean seven dollars. Yeah I got the guy down to seven dollars. And the truck driver just gave me hell you know. He came out and I wasn't there, I was across the street at the hock shop.

MR: I see. Did you get a case with it?

JC: It did have a funny little case. A funny little case. A little, almost like it was made out of paper the little case, it folded over. It was about this long, the whole business, and had a hole in it, wouldn't play. I had to put adhesive tape over the hole. But and then I went later I bought a book, *How to Play the Cornet*, for one dollar. I had an eight dollar investment in this whole deal.

MR: Well considering what you were probably making per hour, you know.

JC: Yeah. I was making seventy-five cents. But anyway then in the book it had a chromatic scale which is every note going up, like every black and white key on the piano. And so at this point my father comes in and I'm showing him this stuff and he says it's really interesting. So he took a pencil and circled the notes to make a diatonic scale, which is [scats], that's a diatonic scale. And so I saw the fingerings for a diatonic scale and I started out. And so the first day I got that down. I could play that in one day. So the next

day I figured I'd play a little song. I go with the cornet [scats] and then I figured out to go [scats]. A blue note see.

MR: You found a blue note.

JC: So once I hit that blue note, that was it, it was blues.

MR: You were hooked.

JC: And I wanted to be a blues player, that was all I cared about, to play the blues, that's all I wanted to do was play the blues, like Louis Armstrong.

MR: That's an important moment, that you could even hear that thing and go for it.

JC: Yeah, and on the second day. So that was, and then I had all this music in my head and it was so hard to get all that to come through that brass instrument. Difficult. So my whole life has been trying to fulfill that.

MR: Well you've done pretty darn good I think. You said this morning, I was interested in a comment you made about World War II and how the music was really affected, almost like that was a benchmark for —

JC: A pretty big change for the country, a huge change. If you think about the way the country was before the war and the way the country was after the war, let's say before the war started, before 1941 the way the country was, and the way the country was after 1951, just think about the difference of the way the country was, all the way up to 1941, I mean there is no freeways, there's no television in the country, there's little towns, everybody knows who their neighbors are. I mean it's a completely different world than we live in now. And since that, about 1950 on, it's much more like the world we live in today. It's a completely different thing. So the music, it's a different — it reflects a different culture. And what I didn't say as well as I could have, because what I meant to say is that when you transfer people from living out in a rural, provincial setting, to the vast majority of people living in big cities, if we apply the same organized teaching systems as opposed to just finding your way on an instrument the way I did and the way early jazz players did like Beiderbecke or some of the early guitar players, now you take people and you really show them systems of how to do this.

MR: Systems, that's important.

JC: And you show people how to play and develop technique very easily. This is the way you develop technique on an instrument. So instead of just having these melodies in your head and trying to get them out through the instrument, now you have all of this technical ability right under your fingers pretty easily and pretty quickly. And that becomes a big part of the style to make big technical expression. And the listening public is very impressed by this technical expression. A lot of times it's not saying much but it's very impressive. So you say wow, listen to what this guy can do. But when you're coming from my place I'm always saying let's hear what he has to say.

MR: And what does that constitute? I mean if people are telling a story, as Mat Domber said, there's going to be an emotional response to it I think he said this morning. Is it possible to pin down, what is that? What makes that happen?

JC: Well I think it's a variety of things that create an emotional response. If you've got Armstrong, playing with a lot of passion and relatively few notes, and not unlimited technique. Now he could play anything he could think. But the whole system of his brain and his self-taught technique meant that his ideas were shaped in a certain way and the limitations become part of the style. So this is really a critical thing. This is really, really important. And that is the limitations are a very critical and important part of the style. So that's one of the things that when you hear Louis you say you're hearing his limitations as well as all his technique, which was vast.

MR: Especially for the time.

JC: Well for the time. In other words, the point is, you want this: enough technique to be able to express the idea. That's all the technique that's needed, to have the idea come out cleanly, beautifully. Here's the idea. And here it is. And that's all the technique you need for that idea. You don't need more.

MR: But a lot of people nowadays have more technique than they do ideas.

JC: Well that's okay. If you have more technique than you have ideas then it's a bunch of wasted stuff that's just in there for the sake of the technique. And just to have music just for the sake of the technique, then I think it's a mistake. I think you've missed the boat, missed the point. And that's one of the reason that we're so fascinated by these self-taught musicians is that it is easier to sense their limitations and so you understand what they're having to say. They talk to you. They speak to you. You feel what they're saying to you. It becomes this emotional reaction to what they're saying to you. You become one with them. Like I feel like I knew Bix Beiderbecke personally and he died in 1931. And I wasn't born until 1941. I feel like I knew that guy. I listen to those things and I feel that I shook his hand, and you know, embraced him and knew him personally. You know it's interesting.

MR: I really like the way you put that. I never quite thought about a person's limitations and how it shaped what they could play. But I know what you mean and Bix's playing seems to look like his pictures too, the photographs of him. I just think he had this sort of vulnerable look to him that you could hear it in his music.

JC: Yeah you could hear a certain kind of melancholy, a little pain or something that's in there. And the more you listen — now you don't hear it at first — but the more you listen to Beiderbecke you hear these little nuances, subtle things. But yeah, the thing about the limitations is sort of profound I think. I think it's very important.

MR: When you think of your own playing, what are your limitations in your own head?

JC: Well you start to play, you have good days and bad days at anything. Playing music is like expressing yourself with language. It's like all of us use creative expression to speak and all of us improvise. Like you've been talking to me and you're not reading from a script, and you've been expressing yourself. Also I've been expressing myself, but you have too. And you're not reading from a script. And playing music is very much the same thing. Sometimes you start to talk and it doesn't come out exactly the way — and you think I didn't say that very well, okay? Like when I spoke this morning and I thought, after my voice kind of echoed on down into the room, I thought I didn't say that very well, I wish I could stop and back that up and say it again, I could do a better job. I could say that better on take two. But there wasn't any take two on that particular thing. And so playing music — I'm talking about my limitations — sometimes you can't do anything wrong, okay? Everything that you play it just, you know you can't make a mistake and you can't, I mean it's just everything is working and the ideas are just coming clearly and freely and they all make sense, it all goes together just right and there it is. But other times it's not working. So and maybe you can relate to that when you try to express yourself in the English language and just talk. Sometimes all the words come out as though you had polished it and written it out ahead of time and made a speech of it. And other times they don't.

MR: When you are playing a tune, maybe you're playing a tune based on rhythm changes, and you get to the bridge, how aware are you of the actual chord changes? And I guess what I'm asking is what do you think about when you improvise?

JC: I mostly think about the melody. I try to keep the melody way back there in the back of my head. It's sort of the — this is what I think is the Armstrong method. Armstrong was a great melody player but the melody is playing in your head and then you're taking liberties with the melody. Now there are other kinds of players who are so conversant with the chord changes that they don't think about the melody anymore. Sometimes they're not even able to play the melody like other players that I have worked with who — clarinetists for example — who are very, very, very able to play up and down all the chord changes and they can name them as they go by which I can't always do, and a lot of times can't. So I mean you can hear them as they go by but not necessarily stop and figure out what they are. For me I'd have to slow it way down and try to figure out what they are and — but I hear them going by. But some of these guys know exactly what they are and what are all the notes in all the chord changes as they're going by.

MR: Are they mostly the fellows who have been through school? Jazz education?

JC: Well like that. Not necessarily. Like one is Allen Vache, who was my partner for a long, long time. He knows all those chord changes and so he's not thinking of every change as it goes by but he certainly knows when he comes to the third chord of the bridge he

knows, and if he doesn't have an idea exactly he knows a note he could go to. So he knows exactly where he's at as a crutch. He has something to go to because he knows it.

MR: Right. He knows it's going to work.

JC: He knows the note that will work there. Where with me, maybe I know the note, maybe I know that this is a D flat chord and I can go to the third of it, but most likely I'm just listening to it and going with a place that sounds good to me.

MR: Um hum. Have you ever had an opportunity where someone writes out one of your solos, transcribes one of your solos?

JC: Yes.

MR: Yes? And then you've looked at it?

JC: Yeah. And I am amazed you know, I see it. Yeah, this happens. Jack Teagarden said that guys had written out some of his solos and he couldn't play them, he couldn't play them.

MR: "I can't play that."

JC: Well an improvised solo is a very hard to thing to play. I've played some Armstrong solos. To play somebody else's improvised solo is — because play a piece of music, play it in a big band, they may have some complicated rhythms and things like that in it, but they're usually not as complicated and difficult as an improvised solo.

MR: Right.

JC: Everybody's solo may have some twists and turns in it that are just almost impossible for you to —

MR: And almost impossible to notate.

JC: To notate, right.

MR: Yeah. As they should be. Interesting. The "Live at the Landing" thing, has that made a huge difference in your life would you say?

JC: You mean the radio show?

MR: Yes.

JC: Well it's made — it has made life more active and more full and it's already full and busy and this just is another activity. However, it's something that I wanted to do and have pursued with some vigor to get it to go. But yeah, it is not for the faint of heart this whole thing, I don't believe. You know you've got to be — because it wears you out. It's a lot going on.

MR: I brought a little piece from one of your shows if I could make it happen here. Oh that's not it, hold on. I wanted to get it up, I will in a second here, because you had a guest, one of our favorite people, and I did want to try to get it up here. It's a guessing game but, one of Hamilton's favorite people.

[audio interlude]

MR: You remember that show?

JC: Yes.

MR: It's interesting to hear this arrangement with the smaller ensemble.

JC: Of course we were trying to make it sound, you know, we were trying to make it sound something like it. That's our rhythm section.

MR: What was Joe like to work with on that show?

JC: Well he was a professional you know. We got up there and we did that and we talked it through ahead of time and I think it was pretty straight forward to go at it. He got in there and got out of there, to do the show.

MR: Is it different working with vocalists than it is with instrumentalists?

JC: Well vocalists have special requirements sometimes. They have special needs, musical needs I mean. I don't mean —

MR: No, I know what you mean.

JC: So in this case we had, that's not our normal band deal and we had recreated this whole thing to make him at home and him comfortable and give him the kind of sound that would make him comfortable, and what he expected and what would feel good to him and would sound natural to him.

MR: Who writes the scripts and so forth that go with it?

JC: Well the scripts, are, almost all the scripts have been written by the executive producer, that's Margaret Pick. Most of the scripts. Occasionally there's one that was written by somebody else, but she's done most, almost all the script writing.

MR: So when it's "Live from the Landing," is someone reading, this is really live?

JC: Well when we first started doing them the idea was we were going to do them live to air. That we were going to go out and they were going to go to people's radios right that minute. And then we did some local shows and we actually did some, I think we did the first couple of shows that we did nationally were actually live to air. We had to rent special equipment, satellite equipment, and bring it in there and beam the thing up right there, and then it was not, that was all complicated. Everything that you do about this is complicated. It has to be a special dish to send this signal up, and then you have to have a place that's big enough to put the thing, it can't be right next to a building. So we're in downtown San Antonio so we had to get a surface parking lot and parking lot and put this thing over on the surface parking lot. Then we had to run the cable around under a bridge and then up and then you've got to get it over the street and then back down to this thing and all that. And then we had to send the signal up. And we were doing the show live to air so then you're going a show that's full of jazz so it's hard to time it right down to the second. So it's got to come out — it's got to end when it's supposed to end, so you have to be, you know there's a clock on the wall and you've got to somehow make this thing come out to zero. So it's not easy to make it work. So we found out that a lot of the

stations were, after we did all this, were taping the show and running it in the most advantageous time slot. And many of them were not putting it up live like we had intended it be, that they might do with it. So after a few tries at this and seeing what the result was we started taping it ourselves. So that's, for all the years the show's been running we've been taping the shows and we put a taped show up on the satellite. But that makes this, getting it to come out exactly to the right time, a little easier.

MR: Yeah. If you need to you can do some editing.

JC: You can edit something out of there.

MR: Right. Isn't it funny you could think well gee Count Basie used to broadcast live from Kansas City, why is it so hard for us to do this too?

JC: Well we used to do it too. When we did our local shows we would listen to a portable radio at the radio station and then the guy would say — I mean we weren't as early as Count Basie, but we'd hear — the guy say it was going on telephone wire — and the guy would say "and now we take you live to The Landing" and we'd start playing.

MR: Hey, sometimes low tech man, works the best.

JC: No, we had a theme. And the drummer would start it, and he had this little five beat thing that he would play. So I would stand and listen to the portable radio, "And now we take you live to 'The Landing'" and I'd go like this, and the drummer would go [scats] and the band would come in [scats]. That would be the theme. So that's the way we'd start the show every day. And so we'd keep watching the clock, we had a clock up there, and we'd get down to the last minute and I'd signal one minute or whatever was going on, and we'd get into an ensemble and make it end in one minute.

MR: That's funny because that's not, you know, like we don't think of music — like a minute of music, well okay, how many measures, how many choruses is that going to be. That's funny.

JC: Well what you do is you'd say, I'd say okay, and then what you'd do is you'd go "bridge" you know. Bridge. Go to the bridge. And you'd get a half chorus, out. And then you'd —

MR: Tag it.

JC: And then you'd have still ten seconds going, and so then I would be, it's still ten seconds to go [scats] hold the thing and watch the thing until it's over. So all those little tricks.

MR: And you hope their clock is synced with the clock at the radio station. Right? That's funny.

JC: Yeah that would be done.

MR: Yeah, that's a good story. The "Porgy and Bess" thing you did, with was it CBS Masterworks? That must have been a thrill.

JC: Well yeah it was great. I had the idea to do "Porgy and Bess" and, because I love that music, and the farther I went into it I said I want to do the whole opera, and that sort of distinguished it from every other pop or jazz version that had ever been done. Because Louis and Ella and Miles Davis and the various ones that existed were all highlights versions. We did the whole opera. We did every song in the whole opera. And then I wrote this narrative that followed the plot. And so then we recorded it and we presented it a couple of times, and we recorded it, and then CBS Masterworks ended up, you know, putting it out. And then we did it all over the country. And I had this narrative that I had written and so the narrator would go out and he would say, "It's dusk at Catfish Row and in the half light a craps game is going on" all this painting the picture of Catfish Row, just giving a quick example. And then he would tell what happened during the first four songs of the opera. And then we would come on and play the first four songs. And then he would come on, or he or she, whoever it was. And what we would try to do would we would get a local celebrity where we were doing the thing on the road. So we would get a local celebrity who was a newscaster or somebody to come and read the script and then they hopefully would talk about it on their news show and help get the audience built up for the thing you know. So all that was going on and we came to Illinois, the University of Illinois, at Champaign or Urbana there, and the lady comes out and she says — I said, "Who's going to do this? You've got somebody from the television station to do the narration?" She says, "Well no, we have somebody on our staff we thought might be able to do a good job on this." And I said, "You didn't get somebody from the television?" "No, we didn't." And this pause. And I said, "Well okay, who is it?" She says, "Well we've got this guy that's in the vocal department here and you may have heard of him, his name is William Warfield." I said, "William Warfield, you mean the opera singer?" She says, "Yes, William Warfield, the singer." And so they trot him out. And so I was very impressed, and you know, having William Warfield. And so after that I said, "Mr. Warfield" he had played Porgy of course in the Metropolitan Opera and done Porgy all over the world. He knew the material better than I did. And so I said, "If you would like to, in making these introductions, sing a little piece of any of these melodies or do anything that you want that you think fits with this, just take it and go with it." And so he would do that from time to time. And it added so much richness to this whole program. So we did it all over the country, took it to Mexico and did it at the Sermentino Festival, which is an international festival. And we were the entry at that festival for the United States with William Warfield being the narrator. And so yeah, it was a fabulous thing and a high point of this whole lifetime of musical activity.

MR: Wow. That's saying something. I was able to interview a fellow who was a child actor in the original production of "Porgy and Bess." His name is Al Tinney. He became a jazz

piano player. But apparently he said he used to sit and play piano duets with Gershwin you know.

JC: Wow. That's quite something huh?

MR: That was neat.

JC: Yeah, I'll bet.

MR: And he talked about it very matter-of-factly, "Oh yeah we would sit at the same bench and play a little bit." But he was young, probably eight years old or something. So man.

JC: There's an interesting story of how the CBS got involved in that but it takes too long I think for this. It's interesting for maybe another year if you interview me again.

MR: Okay, part two. Did anybody say anything this morning or could you add anything about making traditional jazz more a part of the jazz education scene?

JC: Well that's what we're interested in seeing happen and it's one of the reasons that I'm here at IAJE. We would love to see, as time goes by, traditional jazz or earlier forms of jazz sort of like Wycliffe Gordon was alluding to some of these things today, the full spectrum of jazz, from its origins to the most avante garde modern day manifestations of the music, be on display and be present in jazz education. And for most, in the vast majority of cases with jazz education, the attitude has been we start with Charlie Parker and go forward. Charlie Parker is where we start. And there's no question that Charlie Parker was a great genius and everybody is fascinated by Charlie Parker, myself included. I mean everybody enjoys looking and listening to Charlie Parker. It's just an amazing thing that Charlie Parker did. And it took jazz — and it started down a new road, the whole Charlie Parker deal, the whole bebop thing. But that's where jazz at Berklee or North Texas State or when jazz education first began that was where it started. They didn't go — they weren't talking about Louis Armstrong and there was almost, in the early days there was, when I was a young kid people, I would read articles about Armstrong and sometimes they would say Armstrong is a has-been, he's an Uncle Tom, he's — not a disgrace but a lot of negative stuff about Armstrong. And of course I was frustrated by that because having just absorbed these Hot Five and Hot Seven recordings and the early Armstrong, I believed it's — absolutely down to the marrow of my bones that here was the great, great American genius and that it should — there was very little to say that was — and I also would follow him in his later concerts and I was fascinated by all of the eras of Armstrong. He did so much that it was like several different personalities in one life. Like he had several careers, first the great improvising, first the jazz band, second cornet player, then the improvising musician and the hired artist, then eventually you get to the great entertainer and then you get to the singer and so it's all these different things. But at any rate nowadays you read the *New York Times* say Louis Armstrong is the greatest contributor to jazz. But that's a fairly new idea. That's a fairly

new idea. And the fact that we now have that idea on the table changes the game a little bit. And now everybody's going to say, "Hmm, maybe we better look at this thing again and look at it a little differently." And as far as I'm concerned I'd say it's about time that everybody takes a good hard look at jazz. Where did it come from? How did this thing happen anyway? And let's look at the whole picture of the whole history of it. Because, hey, Charlie Parker is now sixty years old. That music is getting to be, see that's old music now.

MR: I know, isn't that something?

JC: That's not brand new cutting edge music. So you have to look back to look at modern jazz. See? So if you're only going to look at this latest new stuff you're going to miss everything. So you have to look — now I mean we've come to thing where they've realized that they have to look back to see Bird, well then you look back beyond that too. So that becomes very logical. Where before it was not logical, but now it's very logical, we'll look all the way back. So I think we're in a changing environment with jazz education. I think as time goes by a lot of these things will self-correct.

MR: You know from teaching jazz in a performance manner, one thing I think may be an issue is that schools are about numbers often times. And the best way to get a lot of kids involved in jazz is to have a big band. And also from a teacher's standpoint who may not know that much about jazz, they can handle a big band sort of because they've got all this music. So they can have a big band, but to have a combo, that's a different story. First of all you don't have as many kids that are going to be involved, and you really have to know a lot more I think, to instruct a combo. So I think that's one thing that makes it harder to teach small group jazz.

JC: We did it at Stanford and every kid that went to Stanford would be part of a combo. Some of the combos were bebop oriented combos but they were still combos.

MR: That's great.

JC: Every single kid was part of a combo. And the combos were all a maximum of about seven pieces. And every kid would have to play some solos. I mean they might have a hard time playing solos but in other words you couldn't just be buried in a section. So, and we need to get, I mean if all you do is just read the music it becomes harder to infuse it with jazz feeling. It's just harder. It can be done of course.

MR: Okay here's a little scenario. The time machine is a reality. Could you pick a couple of times that you'd like to go back to and be around when something happened in jazz history?

JC: Well let me tell you. Everybody that plays this game, right, everybody that's a jazz lover and a jazz fan, has these little — plays this little game in their head. And you go back and you think, and 'cause Eddie Condon writes in this book and it says and so and he says so

he meets Bix and Bix says he wants to go down to hear King Oliver. So they all go to hear King Oliver and they go down there and they stand there and Eddie Condon hadn't been there himself. And he says and so one of the guys says the big guy, that's Oliver, and that other guy's just come from New Orleans, that's the little guy, and his name is Armstrong and his name is Armstrong. That's Armstrong. And so then they started to play and he said and these two cornets were playing like a couple of women talking over the back fence and they were, all the music was winding around each other, and it was pouring off, I mean he used this great rhetoric, it was pouring over like warm cream and flowing down through the holes and all this, I don't know, you'd have to read Condon's words. But so everybody that's old would say all you hear is these old acoustic recordings of Oliver, of this thing. I would like to have gone and stood before the Oliver band, who George Wetting said would sometimes play one tune for half an hour and all the ensemble playing so they'd have to be real strong, and so I'd like to go and stand in front of this thing and hear what that really sounded like. So we did, on one of our shows, we're doing a tribute to King Oliver so we had to get an extra cornet player, a real good guy from California, a tuba player, and the rhythm section to play kind of in this Oliver style a little bit, adjusted just slightly — it had a few peculiarities that were typical, and here we go. And so the Oliver band that the acoustic record is playing, the original record is playing, "Snake Rag." "Snake Rag" has these little descending passages in it. And it's an original piece by Joe Oliver. And the thing comes along [scats] and it has a run [scats] it goes along like this. Okay so we let the thing play about a minute and a half. And it finally comes to one of these passages and the thing goes live see? On the radio. And all of a sudden now you have modern electronics, here it is, and it sounds so great, 'cause now it's not muffled through the acoustic recording anymore. Here is the way it really sounded you know. So when you talk about going in the time machine, we've done it.

MR: That's way cool.

JC: But if you'd like to ask me what else I would like to do, that I've fantasized about, you know there are all kinds of things with Beiderbecke that I've fantasized about. Beiderbecke died in Queens and he died a tragic, down and out situation you know. His last year he was just around and Teagarden said that in the recording studio they would try to record and he overheard him, kind of eerie, talk to the cornet and say, "Don't let me down, don't let me down today" you know. And this guy, he started having trouble playing you know, having trouble, problems, physical problems. But I've thought about going to and knocking on his door you know, knocking on this door and seeing this bleary eyed guy come out and say, "Say, let me see if I can't be of some help to you." You know? And I've thought about that. I thought about hearing him play in his prime, which a lot of people did. I thought about just going around and hearing him play.

Because the people that heard him a lot, Teagarden told me this, said that there was never any experience that he ever had in music like hearing Beiderbecke play live. It was — the records never quite got it. And there was never anything like it. Teagarden said, "I think he was the greatest artist that there ever was in history." Teagarden was such a nut about Beiderbecke. He was just a — and Teagarden was a great admirer of many other players too, and particularly Armstrong. He had heard Armstrong when he was a very young guy and Teagarden was real young, he was only about 17 years old and went to New Orleans and heard Louis play over there. And he was fascinated all the rest of his life. But he said there was just nothing like hearing Beiderbecke play live, the sound and all the passion and everything that was in that thing was so compelling.

MR: And it's amazing that at the same time he was doing that he was writing some of those piano pieces that he did too.

JC: The piano pieces, some of those, they came at different times. But the last couple of those came at the end when he was hardly able to play the cornet and he was having so much trouble. And I think that he would sit there and do these things. Bill Challis went over and took them down and I think that he needed the money. He was literally about to starve you know. That was 1930, 1931, the depression was on, serious problems were going so. So yeah. There's a great new book about Beiderbecke that is the best thing I've ever read about Beiderbecke that was written by a French guy, it's called *Bix*. And it was written in French but it's been translated. It's fairly new. It's by a guy named Leon. L-E or L-I-O-N or L-E-O-N. It's a fabulous book anyway.

MR: Have you ever been to the annual Beiderbecke Festival in Davenport?

JC: Uh you know I've never been to that because they always hold it at late July and we're always involved , we've been involved at Stanford for years and years and years. And so I've never been available. I've been asked. I have been to Davenport three times, been to the Beiderbecke House, I've played the Beiderbecke cornet and I went there for his hundredth anniversary of his birth. We had people from around the world there and we went to the Beiderbecke House and were there right at the moment that he was born in that house, and you know, and did all that stuff. We're cultists. There's a cult.

MR: There was a film that Bob Wilber was involved with, right?

JC: Yes. Yes, that's right. There's a film. But the best thing I think is there was a documentary done by a Canadian lady, it's the best thing. It interviewed Hoagy Carmichael and others. It's the best thing that's been done as a film. And I guess people that go to the internet find it now.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating conversation for me.

JC: Thank you and me too.

MR: If I come down there I expect to get a front row little table.

JC: The tables are twenty inches. They're round and they're twenty inches.

MR: Yeah. That's great. Well you have probably one of the longest running steady gigs of any musician I know.

JC: Going into the 44th year.

MR: Yeah. That's saying something. Well best of continued luck to you and to your staff.

JC: Thank you, Monk.

MR: I appreciate it.

JC: Thanks for doing the interview.

MR: Okay.